

Consider one of the examples involving a trolley car:

Edward is the driver of a trolley, whose brakes have just failed. On the track ahead of him are five people; the banks are so steep that they will not be able to get off the track in time. The track has a spur leading off to the right, and Edward can turn the trolley onto it. Unfortunately there is one person on the right-hand track. Edward can turn the trolley, killing the one; or he can refrain from turning the trolley, killing the five.

Is it permissible for Edward to turn the trolley? If so, wouldn't this be a case in which it is permissible — perhaps even obligatory — to kill one person in order to save five lives?

But then why might it be OK for Edward to turn the trolley, but clearly not permissible for the doctor to cut up his healthy specimen?

One might try to explain the difference here like this: Edward is choosing between **killing one and killing five**; either way, he is killing someone. David is choosing between **killing one and letting five die**, and this is something quite different. We have a stronger duty to avoid killing than to prevent people from dying.

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